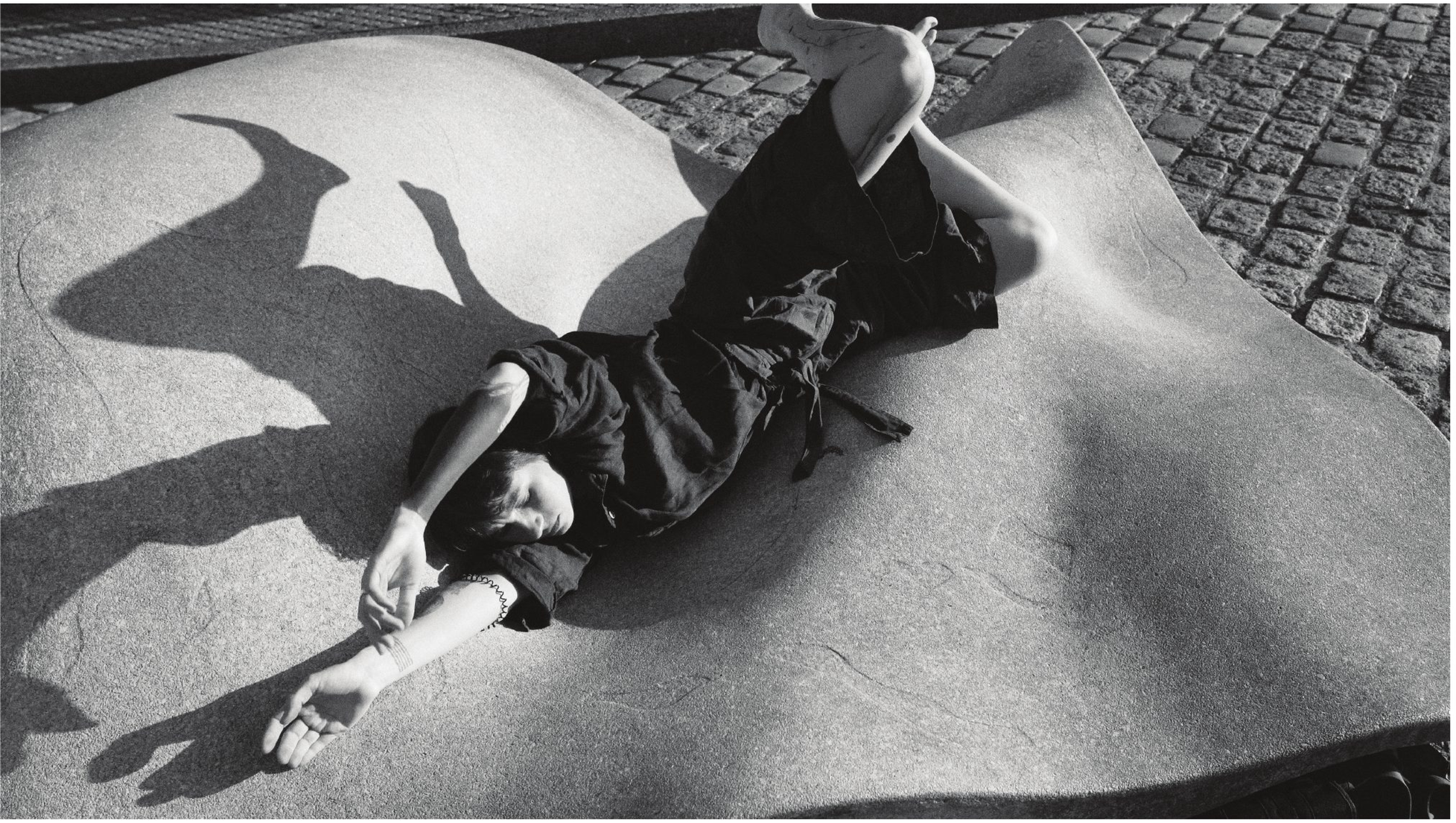


PAULINE PELAGIA BEREZINA

is an artist-researcher of estrangement, working through an ecological frame to read political, somatic and social registers of it. In exile since 2020, born in Pskov, Russia, she has lived and worked in Georgia, Spain and France, and now lives in La Réunion. She works at the edge of site-specific performance, phenomenology and griefwork, in the mediums of photography, moving image, autoethnographical and speculative writing. Her method is direct contact: she works in sites, whether a place or a person, marked by ecological, social, political or emotional catastrophe (a valley threatened by a dam on the Rioni in Georgia (Earthern, 2019–2021), a water purification station in the Ebro delta, the shore of the Black Sea, etc.). What settles out of that contact is a residue: photographs, films, large cyanotypes on silk, sound, texts. Her recent work turns to water. Her concerns are rooted in structural trauma: state violence; land exhausted by the Anthropocene; the everyday misogyny, stigma and social punishment directed at women; the horror of muteness and invisibility of being foreign to any society, no matter the country; borders that cross humans. Since 2025 she has been developing Désarticulé, first shown as work-in-progress at L'atelier des artistes en exil in Paris in September 2026. Trained in psychology and qualitative research, she treats metaphor as a method.

DESARTICULE
(2025-ONGOING)

PT I. WORK-IN-PROGRESS SHOW

L'atelier des artistes en exil, Paris, 19–20 September 2026, Journées européennes du patrimoine. With the support of the Institut français (programme of support for Russian artists in exile, 2025) and L'atelier des artistes en exil.

TEASER, VIDEO DOCUMENTATION









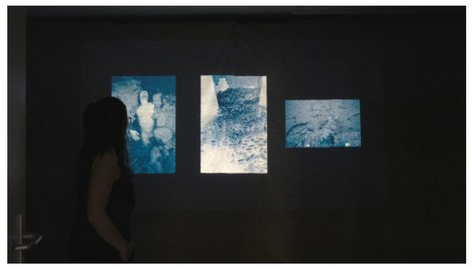


cyanotypes on silk, hung as veils to walk between; photographic series with Others, printed on paper and tracing paper; site-specific performance and moving image, in video projections and on screens; an archive in three projections; a soundscape; autoethnographic texts, phenomenological analyses and theoretical texts; a live noise performance.





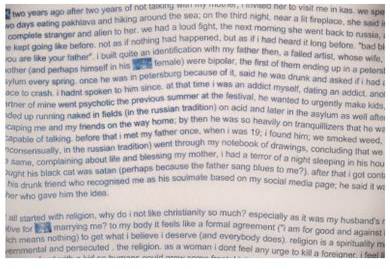




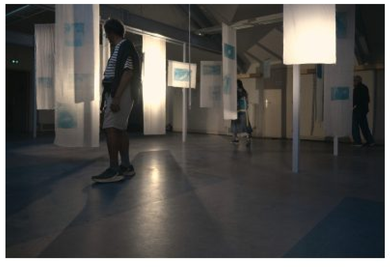


Concept, direction, research, photography, moving image, cyanotypes and texts: Pauline Pelagia Berezina. Soundscape: Pierluigi Scarpantonio. Live performance: Mortall Kombat, 19 September. Participants appear unnamed, by their own choice.

Exhibition views: Pauline Pelagia Berezina and Anoche X.

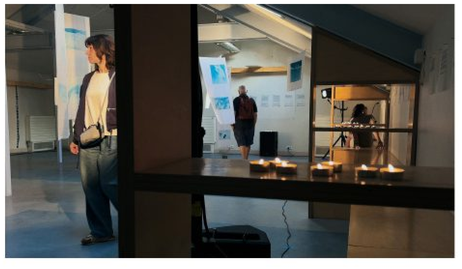

two years ago after two years of not talking
wo days eating pakhlava and hiking around the sea; on the third night, near a lit fireplace, she said i
complete stranger and alien to her. we had a loud fight, the next morning she went back to russia,
e kept going like before. not as if nothing had happened, but as if i had heard it long before. "bad bl
ou are like your father". i built quite an identification with my father then, a failed artist, whose wife,
other (and perhaps himself in his female) were bipolar, the first of them ending up in a peters
ylum every spring. once he was in petersburg because of it, said he was drunk and asked if i had
ace to crash. i hadnt spoken to him since. at that time i was an addict myself, dating an addict, and
rtner of mine went psychotic the previous summer at the festival, he wanted to urgently make kids
ded up running naked in fields (in the russian tradition) on acid and later in the asylum as well afte
caping me and my friends on the way home; by then he was so heavily on tranquillizers that he w
apable of talking. before that i met my father once, when i was 19; i found him; we smoked weed,
consensually, in the russian tradition) went through my notebook of drawings, concluding that we
name; complaining about life and blessing my mother, i had a terror of a night sleeping in his hou
ight his black cat was satan (perhaps because the father sang blues to me?). after that i got cont
his drunk friend who recognised me as his soulmate based on my social media page; he said it w
her who gave him the idea.

all started with religion. why do i not like christianity so much? especially as it was my husband's
tive for marrying me? to my body it feels like a formal agreement ("i am for good and against
ich means nothing) to get what i believe i deserve (and everybody does). religion is a spirituality m
remmental and persecuted . the religion, as a woman i dont feel any urge to kill a foreigner. i feel li





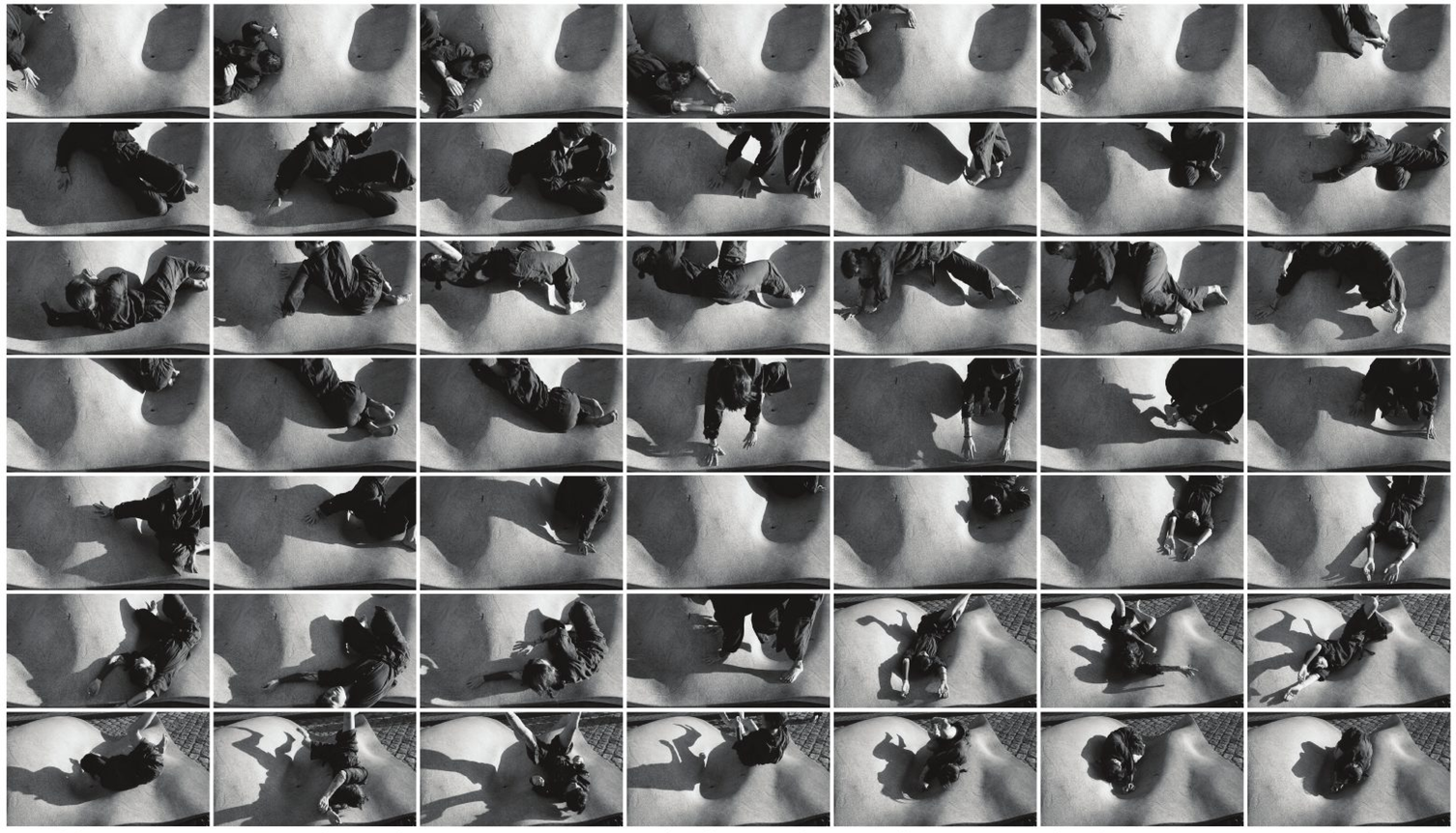




DESARTICULE
(2025-ONGOING)

PT II. CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

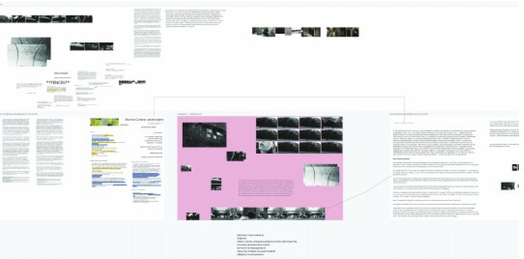
Site-specific performance, somatic research, photography as residue, in-depth interviews and phenomenological analysis, speculative & autoethnographical writing.

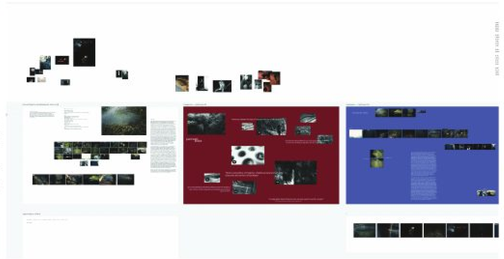


Visual documentation. Critical spatial inquiry, somatic research, photography; La Villette x Bernard Tschumi x Jacques Derrida chapter

Désarticulé, developed since 2025, is an artistic research project about estrangement: the body out of place and its struggle to articulate the facts and the experience of existence. Herself in exile since 2020, Berezina takes foreignness as a ground, the space out of joint where every self dis-articulates, the slow coming-apart at the seams, after Kristeva and Nancy. The core question: what becomes of a body, or of a place, once it ceases to be inserted into a functional, economic or socially recognized system? She goes out and speculates somatically: she spends time with a territory, be it a place or a body, and witnesses it through the camera. The project is fundamentally experiential. Geographically, it has moved between three surfaces: Paris, an urban space already inhabited by exile; the studio, where authentic movement (in the lineage of Mary Starks Whitehouse and Janet Adler) opens the body of the Other as an exiled territory, to be witnessed rather than interpreted; and Wimereux, on the northern French coast, where the shoreline keeps eroding and bodies cross the border at night. Texts run alongside the body work: writing as the passage from affect to effect; with archival, metaphorical images they form a hybrid material moving toward a book. The first chapters were shown at L'atelier des artistes en exil in Paris on 19 and 20 September 2026, with the support of the Institut français: photography, moving image, cyanotypes on silk, site-specific performance, sound and autoethnographic texts. Since then Berezina has lived in La Réunion, home port of the Marion Dufresne. The next chapter, **mal de terre**, takes the same questions to the Terres australes françaises: islands that kept their plants and birds by staying far from any mainland, and now defend themselves against every arrival, down to the dust on a visitor's clothes. By holding what remains outside the frame, the project proposes a method of engaging with what is non-symbolised, marginal, structurally invisible: a contribution to artistic research, critical spatial practices and visual epistemology.

Theoretical ground. Estrangement and intrusion: Kristeva (Strangers to Ourselves, Black Sun), Nancy (L'Intrus). Bodies and environments: Alaimo (Bodily Natures), Haraway (Staying with the Trouble), Tsing et al. (Arts of Living on a Damaged Planet), Barad (Meeting the Universe Halfway). Moving and witnessing: the authentic movement lineage of Whitehouse, Adler, Chodorow, Stromsted and Sager; Laban and Bartenieff; Sheets-Johnstone (The Phenomenology of Dance); Grotowski (Towards a Poor Theatre); Hijikata and butoh. Method and writing: Kvale (InterViews), Depraz, Varela and Vermersch (On Becoming Aware), Arlander et al. (Performance as Research), Ahmed (The Cultural Politics of Emotion), Lorde (Sister Outsider), Bataille (Inner Experience), Genet (The Thief's Journal).









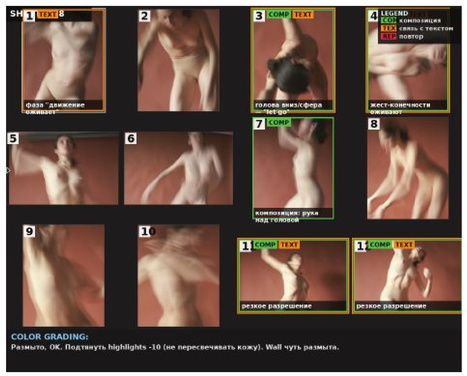




Visual documentation. View Foundation laboratory on photographic research & autoethnographical writing based on project data

DESARTICULE
(2025-ONGOING)

PT III. WORKING MATERIALS

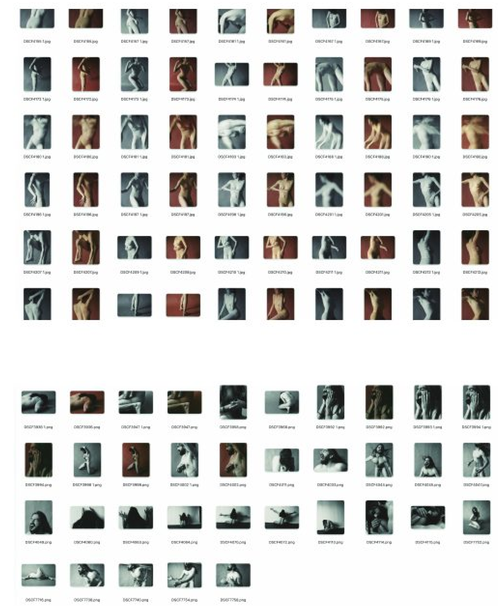


Visual documentation, analysis of images based on interview data, Humans branch





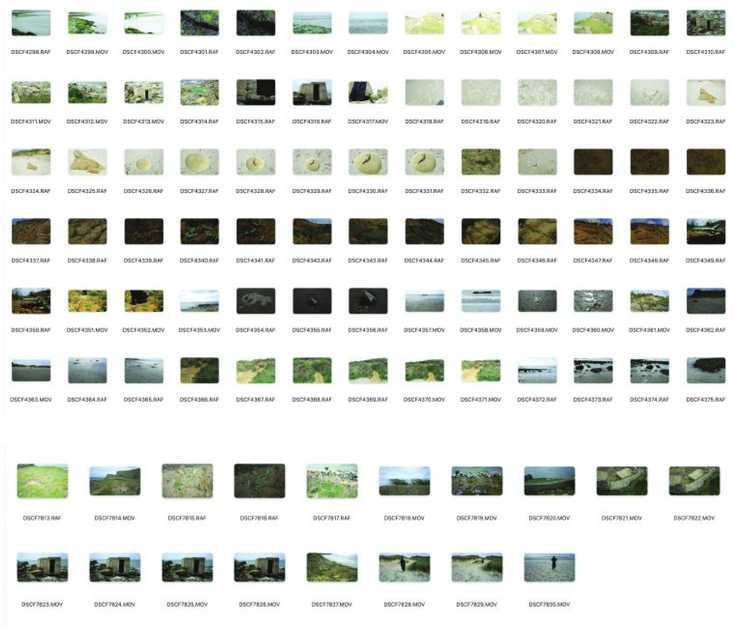
In-depth semi-structured interview & somatic session transcripts as qualitative data, Humans branch



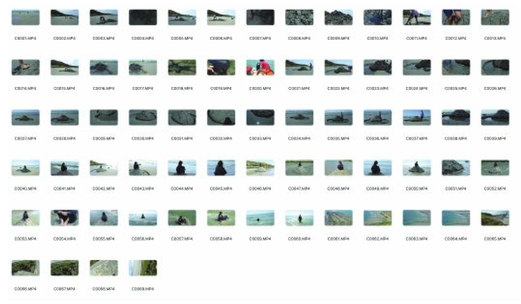
Visual documentation. Humans branch (studio, somatic research in the tradition of authentic movement, photography)



Visual documentation. Critical spatial inquiry, somatic research, photography; Le Central Telephonique Murat chapter



Visual documentation. Research phase moving image archive, Wimereux chapter, May 2026



Visual documentation.Aderian gesture study Moving image archive, Wimereux chapter, August 2025

Solo exhibition, Fotografia Gallery, Tbilisi, 8–22 March 2021,
following nineteen months of research-based work
(August 2019 – March 2021). The project took earth
both as medium and as frame, engaging local people,
raw materials and the environmental concerns
of the Ajara region in western Georgia.

Sculpture, performance, cinema and canvas were folded
into a single gesture across fine art, somatics and ecological activism.







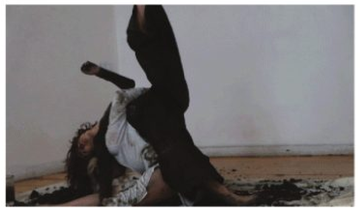




EARTHERN

Curation: Pauline Berezina
Sculpture: Pauline Berezina
Performance and canvas: Pauline Berezina & Natia Chikhvaidze
Guest work: "Namakhvani" documentary film, Leo Descristoforo & Marina Kaganova
Documentation of performance: Sofya O
Photo documentation: Pauline Berezina

Sculptures later were exhibited in Milan (Studio RO, 6.06-31.12.2022) and
Cersaie (international fair of architecture, 2022), the video of performance
was screened at CCA (2021), Video Peace Traffic / Moving Image festival, Tbilisi









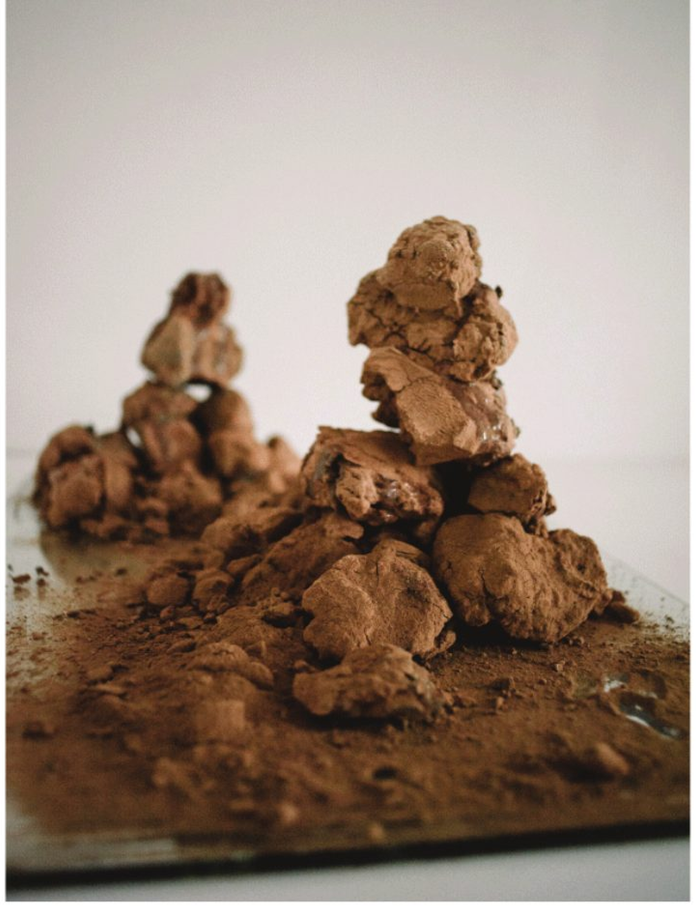










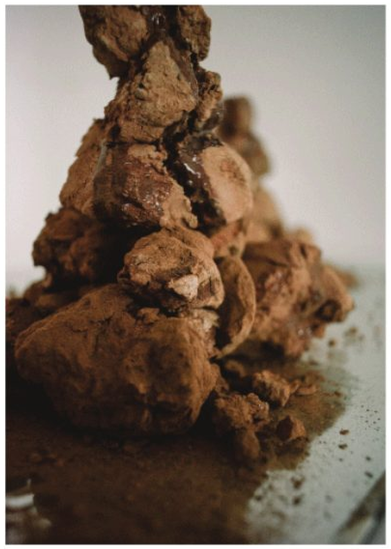






RIONI VALLEY PERFORMANCE ↓

With Natia Chikhvaidze, 3 March 2021 The artists worked with soil from the Rioni Valley, the site of the contested Namakhvani hydroelectric dam in western Georgia, and produced a 2.7 × 3 m canvas: a two-bodied study of how environmental and social pressure register in flesh before they register in language. The canvas hung on the gallery wall; the performance video looped beside the sculpture for the run of the exhibition (Earthern, Fotografia Gallery, Tbilisi, 8–22 March 2021).



































RIONI VALLEY SCULPTURE ↑

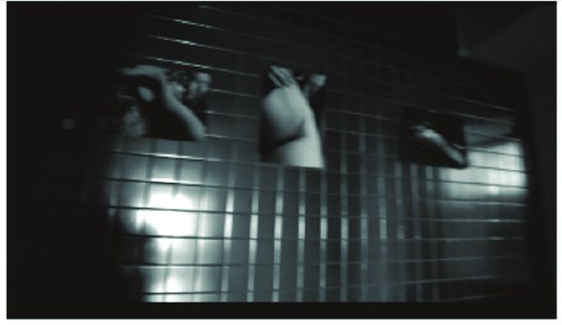
The sculpture was made from Rioni clay collected at the dam site, glazed and fired, then disassembled and reassembled inside the gallery; it carries the dam's disruption and the valley's older weight in the same object.

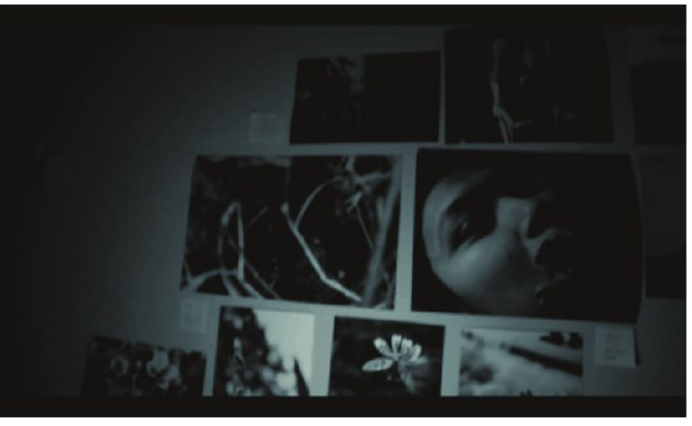














OBSCURE







Solo exhibition
Eleven Window, Tbilisi
24–30 December 2021
Sound: Tete Noise











Photography, video documentation of performance and objects assembled in a candle-lit space. Bodies and nature held as linked subjects, neither subordinate to the other. The title names a condition: what resists certainty, what stays unresolved. In a culture that categorises emotion as either productive or pathological, the exhibition refused that triage and proposed witnessing instead. "Reality is neither fixed nor comprehensible, yet its weight is undeniable. Feeling that weight — without rushing to define or escape it — is, in itself, a practical miracle.".

Works and curation: Pauline Pelagia Berezina;
sound: Tete Noise; opening sound: Santebela

CAP ROIG.
MAN UNDER WATER

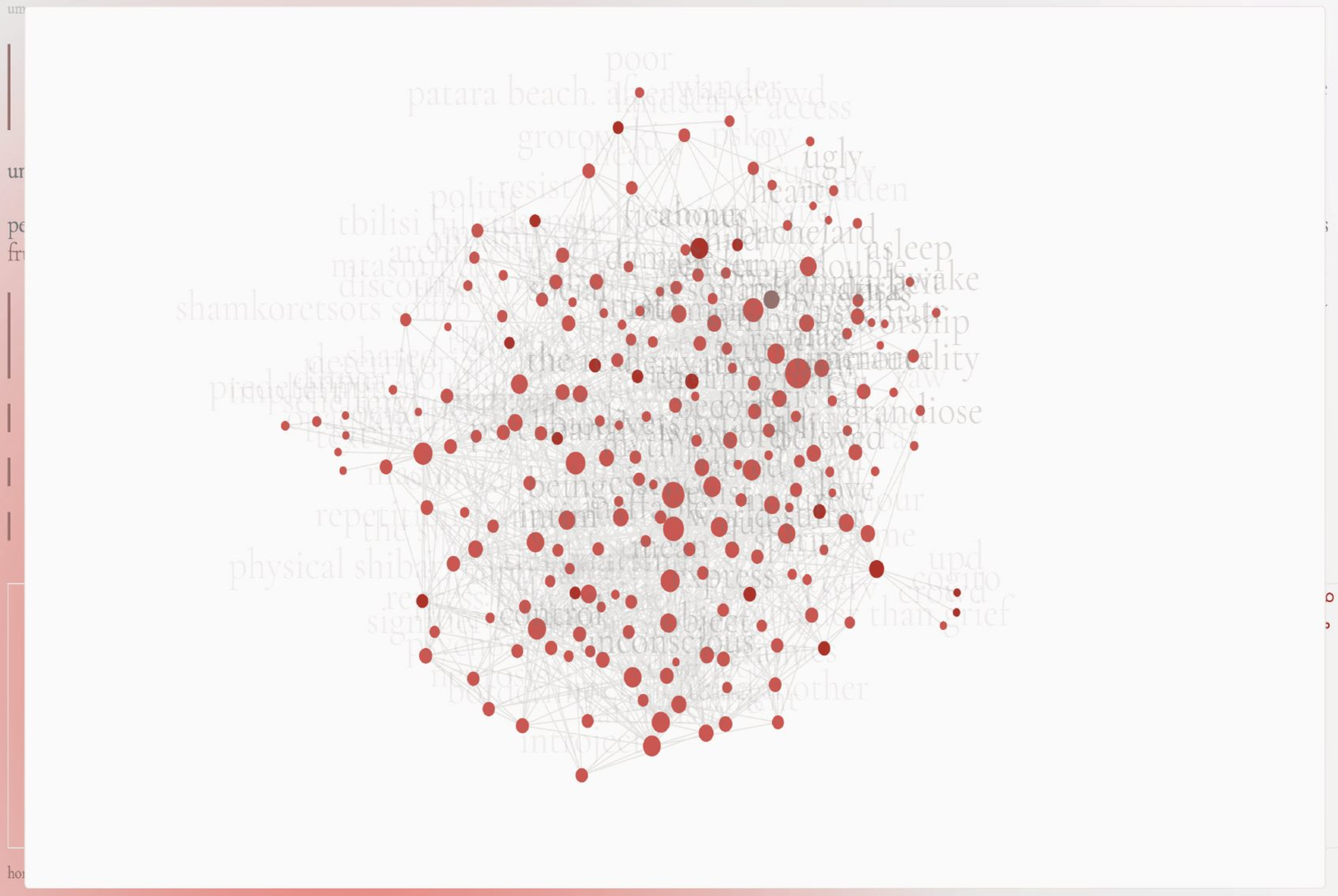
Somatic research, photography. Spain, 2024

What happens to masculinity when it is suspended
in a marine environment: the armour unfastens, weight reorganises,
the archetype yields to drift. The series belongs to a wider inquiry into
ecological embodiment, the visual changes that occur when human
subjects enter more-than-human elements directly instead
of observing them from the shore.



An editorial experiment online at cestlaberezina.github.io/-/, ongoing since 2024.
A website of meanings organised by associative linking rather than by hierarchical convention: each word a node, each click a small migration between meanings. The map treats reading as a somatic act and proposes the dictionary as something closer to mycelium than to a tree. It belongs to Berezina's wider inquiry language: how proximity between concepts is produced, mediated and felt, how a word can be defined by its connections.

UNIVERSAL MEANING MAP

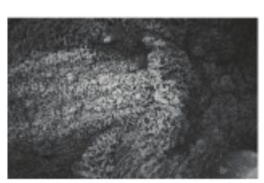
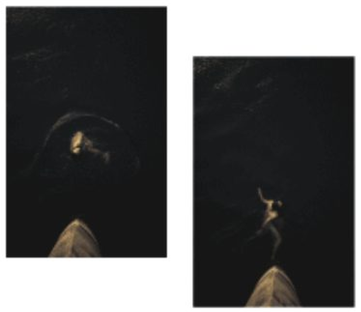


Semantic map, web site. Paris, 2024-ongoing.
Technological idea Xavi Vives, technical support Antoine Depreux

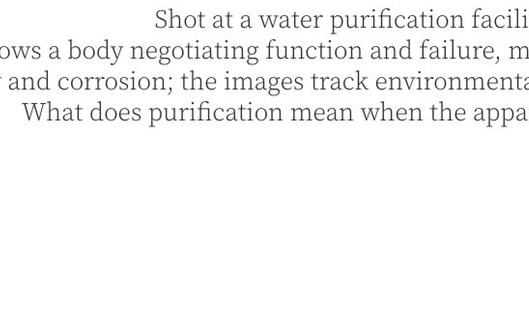
Shot at a water purification facility in the Delta de l'Ebre, Spain, 2024.
The series follows a body negotiating function and failure, movement among steel and seaweeds.
Water (the substance that is to cleanse) reflects delay and corrosion; the images track environmental pressure on a single exposed body.
What does purification mean when the apparatus performing it is itself fatigued?

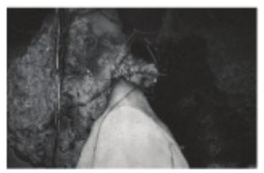
DELTA DE L’EBRE.
PURIFICATION STATION

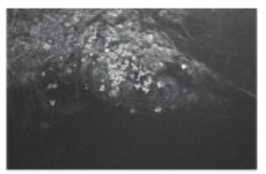






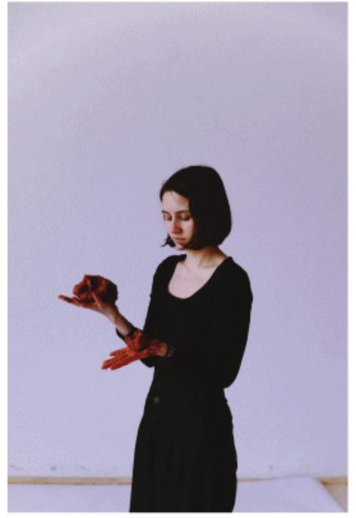



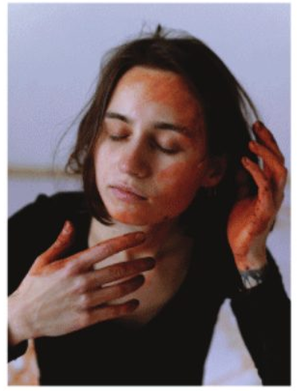

Somatic research,
photography
Spain, 2024

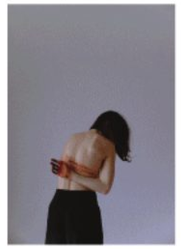
CLAY PT.I

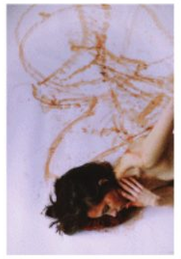


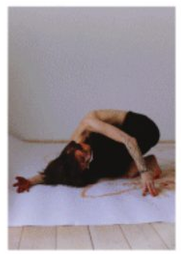














Clay had been studio material, bought for sculpting,
known instrumentally. This performance was
a deliberate refusal of that utility: no intention, no product.
The body entered the material's logic instead of imposing one.
What accumulated on the canvas, rings and smears, is evidence:
of contact, of submission, of a practice learning to unknow.
Somatics meets visual arts; gesture is the primary medium.

Performance.
Saint Petersburg, Russia,
January 2020.









Filmed by Julia Balina.



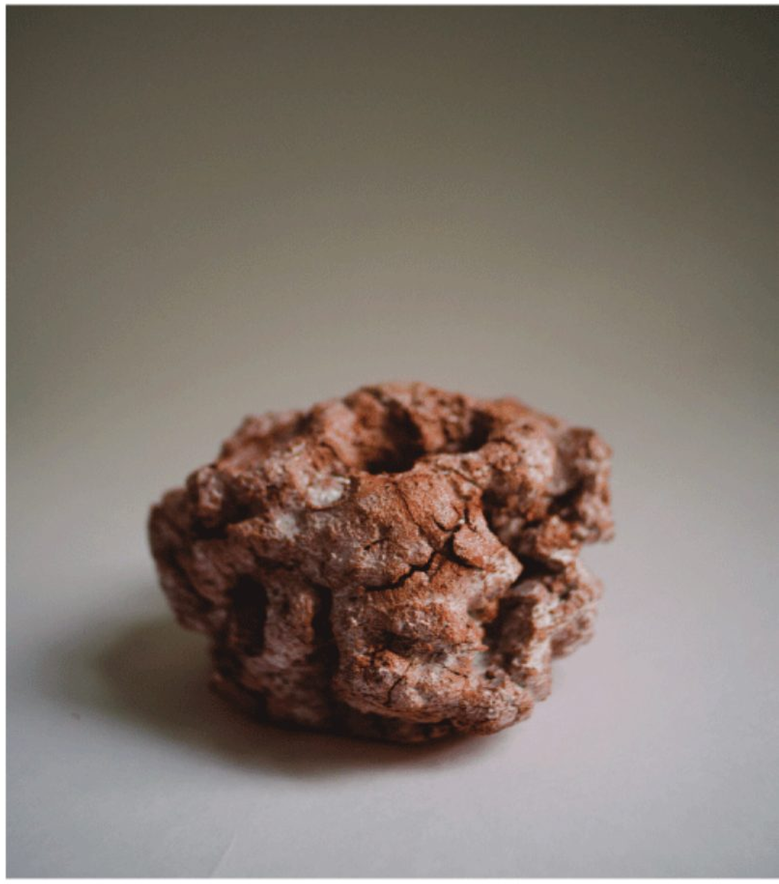
Berezina takes touch as a physical and philosophical encounter at once: who touches, who receives, the space between them, the depth of contact, what remains afterward. Attention shifts away from the surface to the internal dynamics of the material: points of tension, voids, centres that show themselves only as the process unfolds. The clay resists, sometimes more stubbornly than her intentions; the dialogue that emerges places her as listener as much as actor. Tbilisi, Georgia, 2021. Exhibited at Earthern (Fotografia Gallery, Tbilisi, 8–22 March 2021).



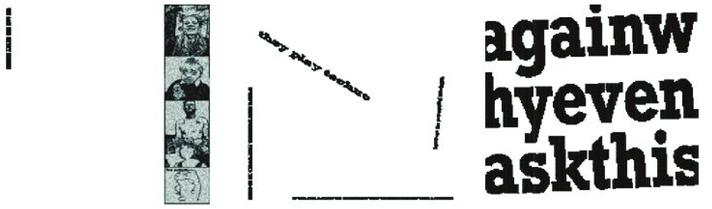
Two sculptures.
Wild, communally collected,
manually processed Brili clay,
fired at 1050

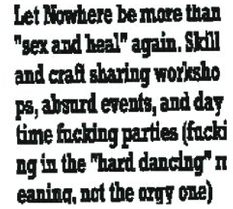




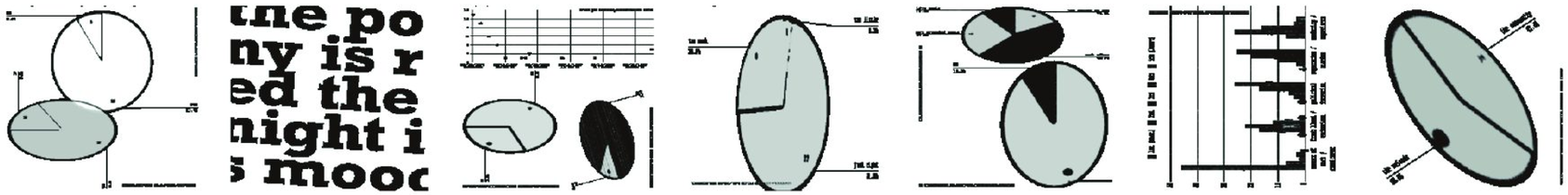


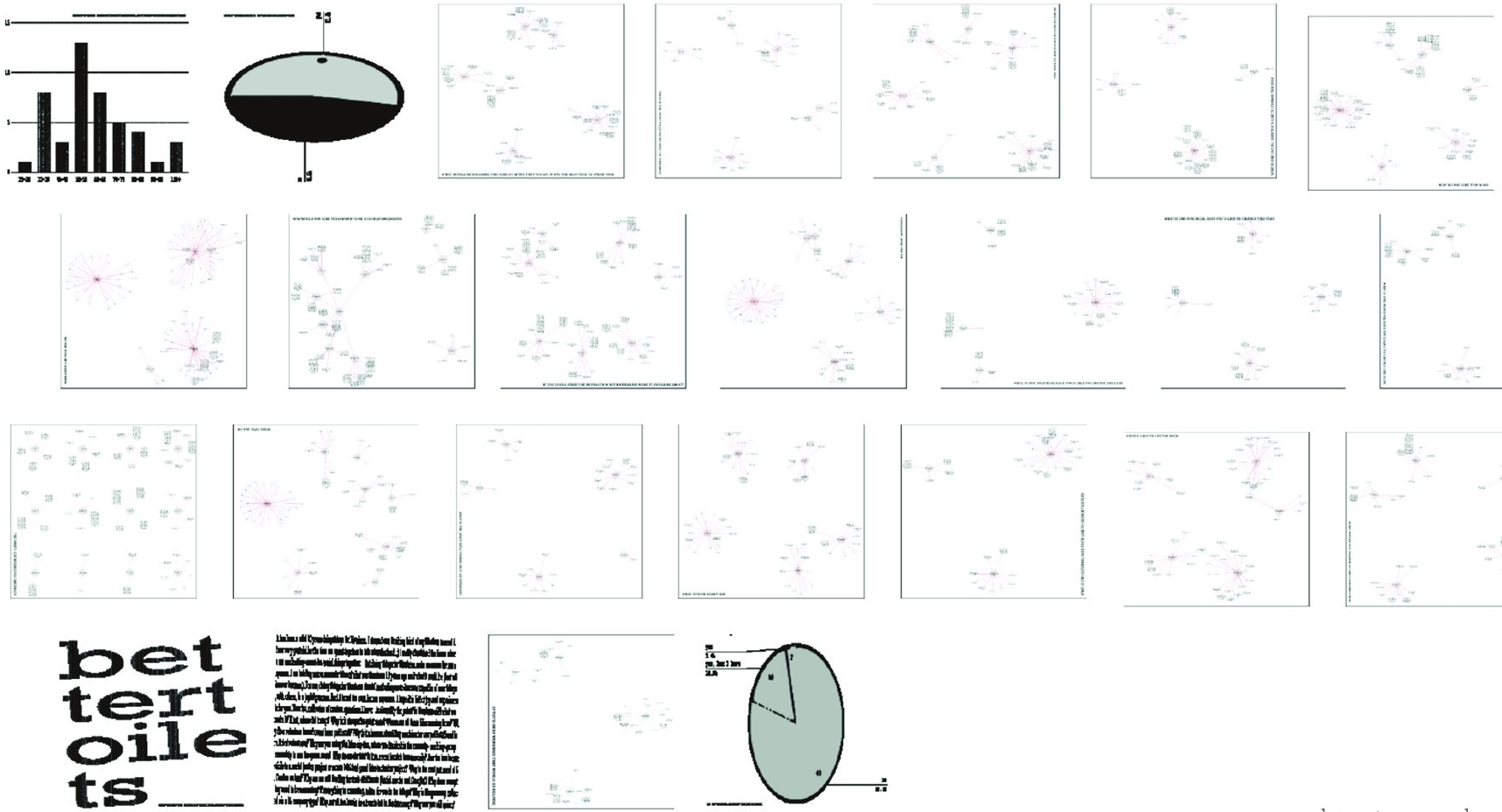
PALPATION











WERKHAUS

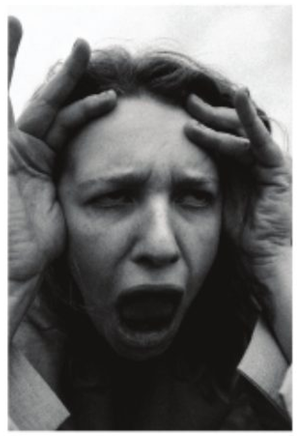
Qualitative study & sociotechnique strategy 2025
For Nowhere festival, Spain, with Antoine Depreux

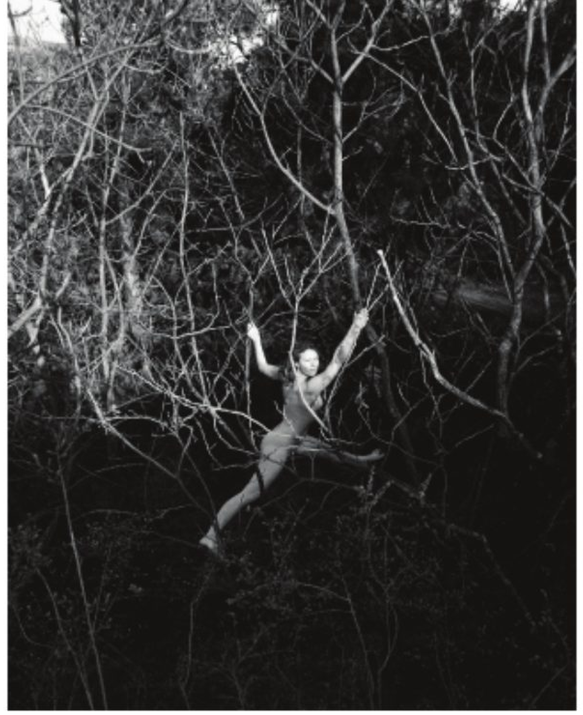
The project examined the internal dynamics of one of the oldest and most engaged campsof Nowhere Festival: commitment, members' capacity for real-life involvement, motivation, contradictions within the festival's ethics, camp-building logistics, political beliefs, values, and the personal, social, political and physical pressures on participation. It also addressed self-organisation, attitudes toward hierarchy and bullying, decision-making models, joining criteria and the practical limits of co-lead authority. Anonymised results were presented and discussed with the members before the event.

The work ran as a social and political experiment inside a 20-year-old festival structure.
Once the camp chose blind voting and majority rule, Berezina and Depreux stepped down: the model conflicted with their political stance and made their presence unnecessary. The camp ran successfully during the festival, with leadership voluntarily distributed across members; in the previous ten years it had been handled by a single person.























MTASMINDA.
EXCAVATION



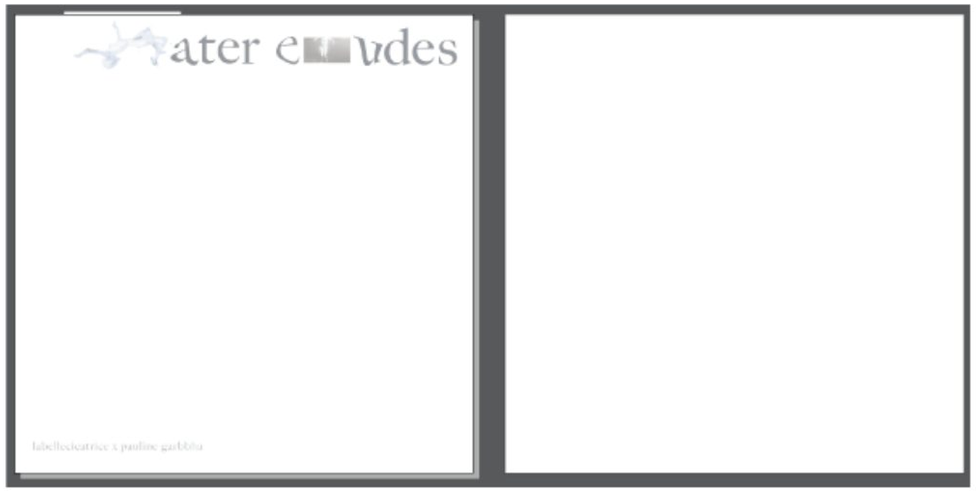
Somatic research, photography
Georgia, 2023



A woman moves through the slopes of Mtatsminda, Georgia: erosion, cut trees, gentrification, moss extinction.
The work uses movement as ritualised self-examination, the body set against the terrain's historical and cultural weight.
The slope is interrogated physically; the body becomes the measuring instrument. Mtatsminda, Tbilisi, Georgia, 2023.

Underwater series captured in the waters around Cap Roig, Spain, 2024
& drawings of graphic artist Bellacicatrice. In progress

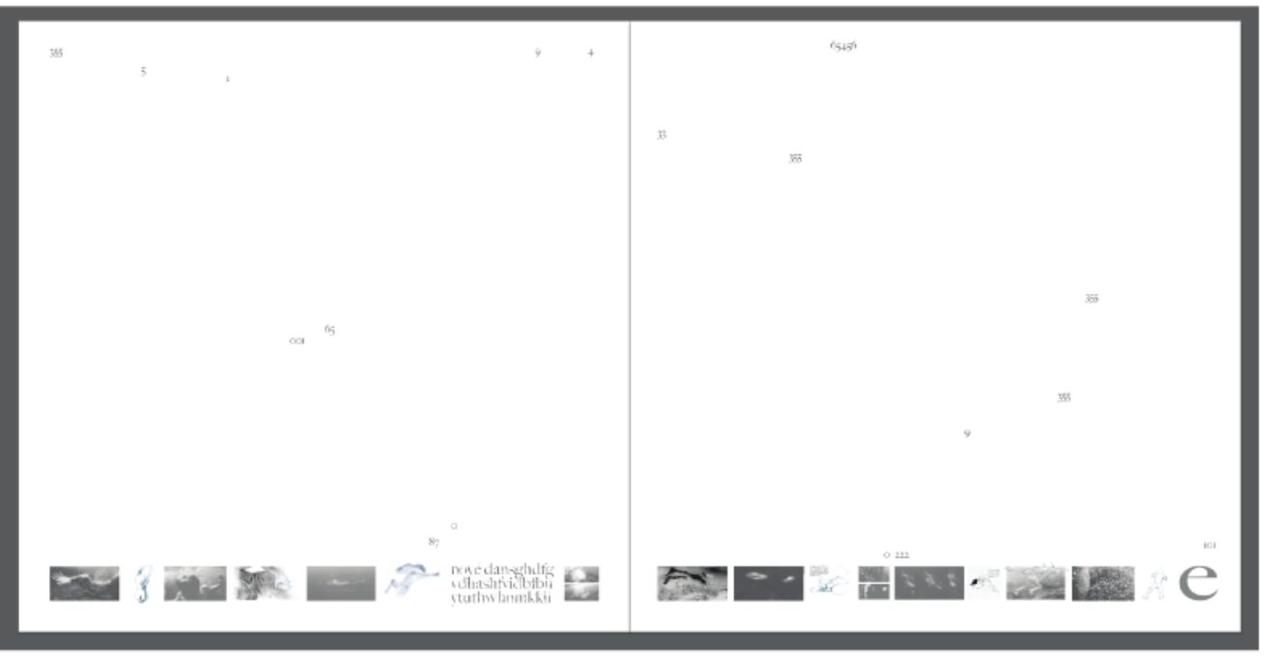
Book project
collaboration with
graphic artist
Bellacicatrice,
Spain, 2024







WATER ETUDES











Somatic research, photography
Georgia, 2024













SHAMKORETSOTS SOURB ASTVATSATSIN











Shamkoretsots Sourb Astvatsatsin Church, an 18th-century Armenian structure damaged by the 1988 earthquake and now threatened by urban development. Berezina introduces foil into the space and transmits catastrophe through reflection: fragments of light bounce off metal and carry both the shimmer of divine iconography and the harsh glare of neglect. A space once shaped by patriarchal religious power is turned into a site of living feminist ritual.
Shamkoretsots Sourb Astvatsatsin Church, Tbilisi, Georgia, 2024.

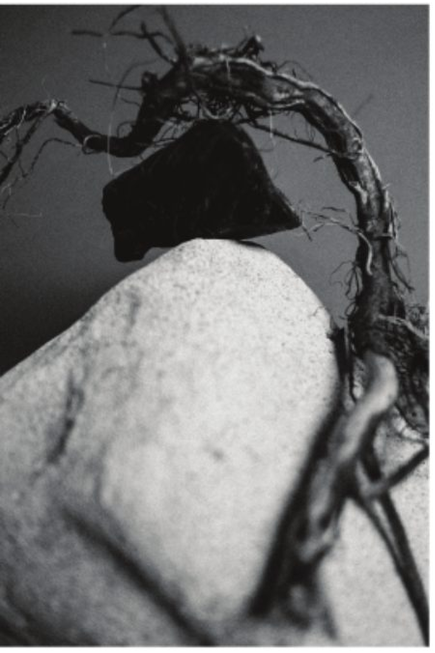




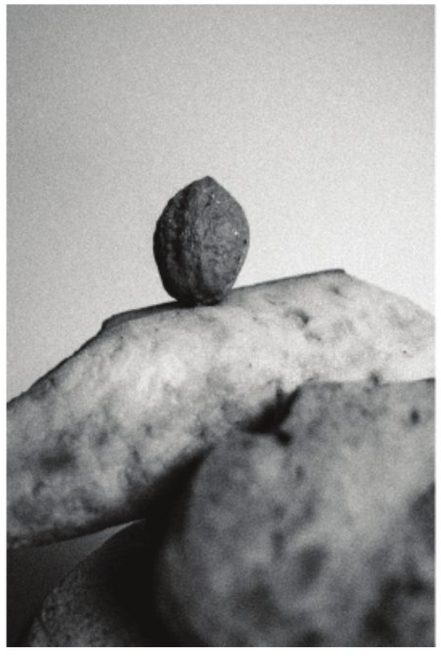




ANAKLIA ETUDES







Still lifes of discarded materials collected along the Georgian Black Sea coast.
Anaklia, Georgia, 2023.



The compositions read the shoreline as an archive: what the sea takes in and what it spits back out, the human residue caught between tide and soil.
They form the body-absent counterweight to the embodied series of the same period.













PHYSICAL SHIBARI PERFORMANCE







Live shibari performance,
Tbilisi, 18 December 2022,
Alea antiwar fundraiser.

Intimacy, control and physical presence carried through rope and motion; trust and negotiation are the substance of what is shown.
With shibari artist Gary S4B and musician Nick Hudson. Funds raised were transferred to Livyi Bereh, the Mayakovsky Case and T-Action.



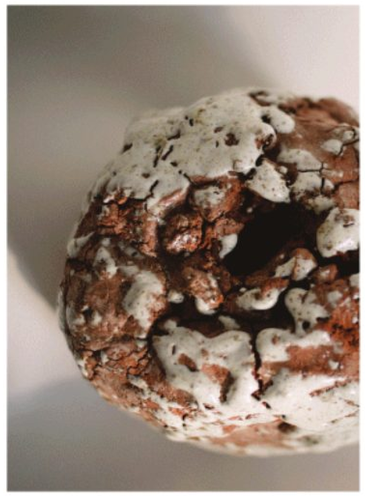


The raw red clay comes from a village in Upper Ajara, Georgia. The work turns to simple forms and primitive techniques and treats the firing's unpredictability and the clay's natural qualities as collaborators. Intentional hollows in the vessels foreground absence; the viewer's gaze completes the piece.





BRILI







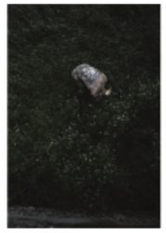




Five vessels, unprocessed Brili clay,
white glaze self made,
fired at 1050 °C.

Exhibited at Earthern (Fotografia Gallery, Tbilisi, 8–22 March 2021).



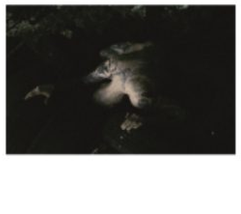


















TABAKHMELA

Somatic research, photography
Georgia, 2023

Set against the skeletal remains of Tabakhmela's abandoned pharmaceutical factory in Georgia, a man moves. He does not perform strength; he tries to remember what strength ever meant. The metal is rusted, the earth smells of old chemicals and animal death, and there is no audience but ruin. The work reads machismo as a posture without ground, an inherited rigidity left behind in a place whose original function has dissolved.